

Creating 'value' beyond the point of production: branding, financialization and market capitalization

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Organization

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Abstract

The contemporary significance of branding as a source of value is explored by situating the creation and valorization of brand equity within 'the full circuit of capital'. Conceived as a form of co-production occurring in the sphere of circulation (as well as production), brand-building is connected to: the surpluses generated by the labour of user-consumers as well as the designers and producers of branded products and services; the realization of surplus through control of revenues derived from sales of these products and services and the appropriation of surpluses, including the conversion of brand equity into brand value after deduction of costs. Contemporary investment in branding is related to the financialization of brands as intangibles that make a growing contribution to market capitalization. By attending to multiple facets of the circuit of capital, including the co-production brand equity by user-consumers, some pointers are proposed for developing a more 'joined-up' view of the 'bigger picture' of contemporary capitalist reproduction.

Keywords

brand equity, co-production, ethical surplus, financialization, full circuit of capital, intangibles, Samsung, social networking, valorization

... brand owning companies can earn huge returns on their capital and grow faster, unencumbered by factories and masses of manual workers. Those are the things that the stock market rewards with high price/earnings ratios. (Akasia, 2000: 30)

What is value and how is it created? Claims about 'value', and assessments of these claims, tend to be presented, debated and justified in relation to what is taken to be their capture of some, or all, of its essence.¹ The position advanced here, in contrast, doubts that 'value' has any essential

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meaning. Propositions about value are interpreted as articulations of ethico-political complexes (see below), and not as more or less adequate representations of what value 'really is'. The present analysis offers a political *cultural* economy of the value created by branding.

It is its lack of any essential meaning which enables the concept of 'value' to accommodate many, diverse meanings. Within the discursive terrain of economic life, there are multiple values which include use (or functional) value, exchange or market value, and symbolic or sign value. This plurality does not imply that 'value' is too ill-defined or vacuous to be intelligible or significant. To the contrary, value is a flexible and capacious signifier that becomes filled with diverse meanings that extend to 'aesthetic value', 'ethical value', and so on.

Competing senses of 'value' are inspired and supported within particular *ethico-political complexes*. For example, the complex of feudalism is distinguished by institutionalized deference to local lords, and ultimately to a ruler embodying divine right; and the complex of capitalism is distinguished by its institutionalized celebration of the private accumulation of wealth through harnessing freely traded labour. Each complex lends plausibility and virtue to particular meanings ascribed to 'value' (see Graham, 2002; Graham and Jones, 2005). Establishing and maintaining the institutions (e.g. markets) comprising ethico-political complexes depends upon mundane constructions and expert advocacy of what Weber terms 'value-orientations that are 'simultaneously theoretical and practical' (Brubaker, 1984: 62) and which 'constitute the framework within which interests are defined (Brubaker, 1984: 63). With regard to contemporary capitalism, 'expert' and lay proponents of dominant, neo-classical thinking attribute value to goods which satisfy the subjective perceptions and preferences of persons as utility-maximizing individualists. From a neo-classical standpoint, the creation of websites such as *YouTube* or *Facebook*, for example, is (normatively) interpreted in terms of utility to their visitors. In contrast, proponents of classical theory, and especially Marxian critique of political economy, relate the creation of value to the exercise of human labour power. From a Marxian perspective, the value of *YouTube* is framed in terms of the *wage labour* that is objectified in its design and content. From a post-Marxian stance developed here, attentiveness to value creation extends to the sphere of circulation where the labour of unwaged user-consumers is seen to participate in providing the content, and thereby to building the brand equity, of such businesses.

The term 'ethico-political complex' underscores how, as value is more or less explicitly placed upon 'this' (e.g. 'exchange') rather than 'that' (e.g. 'use'), the construction of social reality is an endemically ethical undertaking. More grandly put, all social constructions comprise a precarious moral membrane, or 'canopy' (Berger, 1967), in the face of other, possible ethico-politically charged possibilities. It is (recurrent) moments of choice, or decision—whether comparatively reflexive or more habitual—that reproduce or transform social realities. Their formation and alteration are materially conditioned, but are not propelled, by economic forces. It is the hegemonic value invested in particular practices (e.g. the practices of consumption or of production) that is critical for social reproduction and transformation. In Gamble's (2009: 143) words, 'The establishment of the conditions under which economics drives politics can only be done through politics'. 'Politics' endows the world with particular meanings that offer precarious fixes for, but repeatedly fail to overcome, 'the ethical irrationality of the world' (Weber, 1946: 122). Hegemonic 'fixes' that establish and maintain ethico-political complexes are inherently unstable and contestable, not least because they are pregnant with unintended consequences.

The conjecture that value lacks any essential meaning does not preclude the adoption or revision of particular notions of value (e.g. classical or neo-classical ideas) *so long as* the meaning(s) attributed to value are recognized to be articulations of ethico-political complexes, and not passed off as

reflections of supposedly essential qualities. How might this perspective be relevant for studying branding and for analysing the sense of value associated with brands as intangible assets; and, more pointedly, is it credible to suggest that 'brand value' is constructed within particular ethico-political complexes? The value attributed to branding, it will be argued, is conditioned by layered phases of the development of capitalism conceived as a dynamic ethico-political complex. Initially, branding accompanies and enables an expansion of alienated exchange by offering the reassurance of standardized quality indicated by a brand name and/or logo to prospective purchasers of impersonally traded goods. In a second phase, the ethico-political significance of standardized quality is elaborated to enhance the symbolic appeal of products or services as distinctive (e.g. 'sexy', 'cool')—that is, exploring and amplifying the possibilities presented by what Marx terms the 'metaphysical subtleties and 'theological niceties' of commodities (see Harvey, 2001). This increases what is termed brand equity (e.g. recognition and loyalty) as it further stimulates mass consumption. Then, in a third phase, the brand assumes a monetized value as an intangible asset. This article is principally directed to an exploration of this phase where

Brands are financial assets and their importance in relation to the tangible assets of most businesses continues to grow. The management of brand value is simply another aspect of managing shareholder value. (Batchelor, 1998: 101)

How, then, is the term 'value' being invoked here to examine the monetization of brand equity? Without attributing to it any essential quality, the term 'value' is used, in a post-Marxian manner, to illuminate the generation and distribution of wealth through the production of symbolic artifacts, including brands, in the context of an increasingly financialized economy (see Exhibit 1) where intangible assets assume a leading role and importance. Such assets, as Serfati (2008: 45) observes, 'add one new, less addressed layer to financialization' which, resulting from a liberalization of markets, has been central to a post-1970s–2008 recuperation of profitability.

Exhibit 1. Financialization

The term 'financialization' has been invoked and defined in numerous ways (Krippner, 2004). It is here taken to refer to a contemporary drive to subordinate and reconstitute all forms of economic activity—consumption as well as production—in relation to its financial relevance and significance. A widely commended definition of financialization is offered by Epstein (2005: 3): '... financialization means the increasing role of financial motives, financial markets, financial actors and financial institutions in the operation of domestic and international economies'. The present analysis is consistent with this formulation as it gives as much attention to 'financial motives' and 'financial markets' as it does to financial institutions. A rather narrower conception of financialization focuses upon the growing dominance of financial institutions in the global economy; and a wider definition extends beyond 'economies' to everyday life (Martin, 2002). Of course, financialization is not new and, arguably, is a potential inherent to capitalist accumulation (see Kindleberger and Aliber, 2005). In the post-1970s era of neo-liberal deregulation, financialization—in the sense advancing a 'pattern of accumulation in which profit-making occurs increasingly through financial channels rather than through trade and commodity production' (Krippner 2004: 14)—became an increasingly important driver of growth. As we shall see, the monetization of brand equity is an area where 'financial channels' interact with, and increasingly condition, the (re)organization of 'commodity production' within increasingly globalized value chains.

The 'new layer' is analysed by adopting a revised classical political economy framework in which the cultural production of value orientations is assigned greater significance than in more orthodox forms of analysis. In this regard, it is conjectured that cultural 'discourses of finance and management'—such as the discourse of shareholder value (Ezzamel et al., 2009)—'shape rather than observe processes of financialization' (Erturk et al., 2007: 44). Proponents of a political cultural economy perspective endeavour to interrogate, challenge and transform—rather than reflect, capture or legitimize—the dynamics of advanced capitalism, conceived here as a particular ethico-political complex. More specifically, such analysis attends to the culturally mediated contribution of user-consumers, as co-producers, in generating the equity secreted in brands; it also attends to how this equity is monetized and privately appropriated as property rights are asserted over the use and disposal of such intangible assets; and, finally, it appreciates how this appropriation is underwritten by the means of violence vested in the legal system within capitalist states (Coombe, 1998).²

By relating branding to analysis of the 'bigger picture', which includes the role of the state in organized capitalism as well as contemporary processes of financialization, this approach is responsive to criticism that studies of branding, and of consumption more generally, tend to be 'uneconomised' and 'oversocialised' as their focus is predominantly upon 'the individual and social rewards' (Cova and Dalli, 2009: 326). The present, 'economised' analysis of branding, in contrast, pays attention *inter alia* to the 'the disparity in the distribution of profits arising from consumers' work' (Cova and Dalli, 2009: 326) as co-producers of brand equity where, in an era of financialization, this equity is ascribed a monetized, dollar value as a financial asset. An orthodox Marxist analysis with its focus upon the productive activities of wage labour in workplaces is thereby revised to consider how value-productive activity is increasingly occurring in the sphere of circulation. Any claim that labour is exploited—whether in the sphere of production or circulation—is understood to articulate a particular ethico-political orientation; and, *contra* scientific Marxism, this post-structuralist, post-foundationalist approach doubts the possibility of making an independent or non-self-referential (e.g. 'scientific') justification of its claims.

The article is organized as follows. In the first section, the meaning of value is elaborated. The second section explores the development of branding and the potential for brand equity to be monetized through processes of 'brandization'. The third section discusses the contribution of user-consumers to the building of brand equity. The final section focuses upon the relationship between financialization and branding where the process of translating brand equity into brand value is elucidated, using *Samsung* as an example.

Making sense of value

From the perspective taken here, absence of consensus on the meaning of 'value', its creation and capture is not attributable to as-yet-imperfect theories or metrics. Consensus is elusive as a consequence of incompatible normative frameworks embedded in ethico-political complexes. Competing conceptions of value are effects of struggles through which new complexes emerge and become institutionalized. They do not reflect or capture some aspect(s) or essence of what they aspire to disclose. Particular notions of 'value' become meaningful, achieve 'grip' and exert their effects through processes of contestation. Arvidsson (2009) expresses a similar view:

Since value is a normative concept, it follows that standards of value are socially constructed: they are the result of political struggles and, consequently, they vary from one social formation to another. (Arvidsson, 2009: 16)

To this can be added the understanding that standards of value also vary *within* ethico-political complexes in ways that circumscribe ‘value’ as a field of study. When, for example, the creative power of labour is associated with workplaces in which goods are manufactured, the field is located in the workplace; and other ways of divining value, notably those that attend to the sphere of circulation, are regarded as misguided or false. The neo-classical focus upon subjective preferences exercised in the sphere of circulation is, from a Marxian perspective, ideological—a view that affirms the *virtue* of restricting the study of value to the workplace.³ Thompson and Smith (2009: 922–4), for example, acknowledge the presence of different moments of political economy—production, circulation, realization—but also assume their time-space distinctiveness so that the sphere of circulation is conceived as external and epiphenomenal to productive, value-creating activity. When this assumption is made, critical analysis struggles to make sense of forms of value-productive activity—such as the co-production of the symbolic values that comprise brand equity—that occur outside of an employment relationship (see also Foster, 2007, 2008).

Studying value critically?

The virtue of studying the sphere of production and the employment relationship is that, from a Marxian standpoint, it affords an appreciation of how the creation of exchangeable products and services depends upon subordinating and disciplining the value-producing powers of wage labour. Sellers of labour are shown to be dispossessed of the means of production, degraded in the execution of what others design, and rewarded for only a fraction of the surplus that is realized from the sale of what they produce. From this standpoint, attentiveness to the (fetishised) ‘exchange value’ of commodities in the sphere of circulation is associated with (bourgeois) analysis where the ‘hidden abode of production’ is disregarded, and where the value appropriated by the owners of productive assets is regarded as a necessary reward for entrepreneurial risk-taking.

The perspective adopted here retains a connection between value and labour power but it assumes an ethico-political, rather than scientific, basis of this relation. It does not assume some essential meaning of ‘value’ that is objectively attributable to ‘labour’, and which leads to an entanglement in debates over ‘the labour theory of value’. Labour is here distinguished by its creative (and self-reproductive) capacities, and not by whatever value, whether material or symbolic, it is assessed to create. The specific focus of the analysis is the creative participation of user-consumers in building brand equity. In the process of creating brands, the role of the consumer, as co-producer, resides in recognizing the brand, and attributing qualities (e.g. reliability, prestige) to it. This process is enabled, but not determined, by the labour of product developers, packaging designers, advertising specialists and so on. As Goldman (n.d.) puts it, those who seek to increase brand equity ‘try to encode a sign by prompting an exchange of meanings. But, *it is on the decoding side of this “forced” exchange that a sign is either valorized or not*’. These processes of co-production now extend to activities such as ‘crowdsourcing’ (see Kozinets et al., 2008; see also Business Week, 2006; Cook, 2008) as internet platform owners (e.g. *YouTube*, *Lego*) mobilize the labour of user-consumers to develop products and provide content. The perspective favoured here is attentive to how, in the contemporary era of financialized capitalism, the brand equity produced by user-consumers becomes a target of valorization as the monetary value attributed to branded goods, such as *Lego* bricks or *Virgin* broadband, is factored into the stock price of the companies owning the intellectual property vested in the brand. Dividends and capital gains enjoyed by shareholders flow, in part, from the labour power of consumers [e.g. brand communities (see Muniz and O’Guinn, 2001)] as well as producers (e.g. brand managers), who co-create the equity that is monetized.

The point of highlighting this development is not to revise the labour theory of value or to displace labour process analysis but, rather, to draw attention to the contribution of user-consumers in co-producing the (intangible) assets which are an increasingly significant source of privately appropriated wealth. This co-creation is integral to all phases of branding as the consumer does *active interpretive work* on the ‘decoding side’ of processes of brand building. Consumers are not empty vessels for marketing propositions but active interpreters and evaluators of their relevance and appeal (see Jhally and Livant, 1986; Smythe, 1977). In the UK, the early branding of Bass beer and Tate and Lyle sugar, for example, products which became household names with recognizable logos, packaging and so on, required the involvement of consumers in assessing brand messages and sharing their knowledge, thereby co-producing the brand equity ascribed to these products.

This perspective is pertinent for illuminating questions that defy orthodox Marxism—namely, why workers have not realized their ‘interests’ by revolting against their institutionalized exploitation; why user-consumers enthusiastically pay substantial premiums for branded goods, and finally why time is freely given by consumers to refining and publicizing brand-name goods (e.g. Lego) for which they then pay a premium price. Such puzzles are not convincingly tackled by appealing to some version of essential value or false consciousness—such as the argument that capitalist work organization obscures the pumping of surplus value from their labour (Burawoy, 1986, see esp. 32–35), or that consumers are unwittingly hoodwinked or ensnared into paying for the designer label, rather than paying a fraction of the price for an otherwise identical, unbranded product. Instead of assuming that there is an unbiased, objective standpoint from which to survey and disclose the reality of economic relations and declare these relations to be utility-maximizing or exploitative or whatever, the present analysis proceeds from the understanding that both adopted frameworks of analysis and the ‘objects’ (e.g. ‘value’ or ‘branding’) which they aspire to examine—regardless of whether these objects are branded goods or exotic financial instruments (MacKenzie, 2009)—are articulations of particular ethical-political commitments, and in this sense are constitutive, not reflective, of the world that they aspire to know.⁴

Branding and brandization

Branding has until very recently been marginal to critical scholarship across business and management studies (see Arvidsson, 2006; Holt, 2002; Kornberger, in press). Marketers, with few exceptions (e.g. Holt, 2002, 2004), have treated branding as a functional means of differentiating products or services, increasing product recognition and reputation and thereby securing or gaining market share.⁵ Other students of business have been inclined to regard branding as external to their domain, the principal exceptions being organization specialists interested in *corporate* branding (e.g. Hatch and Schultz, 2005; Schultz et al., 2000, 2005) and accounting specialists interested in the issue of accounting for brands (e.g. Tollington, 2001). Attentiveness to branding amongst social scientists, whether mainstream or critical, has also been muted, perhaps because it is viewed as too superficial to merit close or serious examination. It seems that the ‘soft’ and intangible qualities of consumer behaviour make branding an unattractive topic for students of political economy. Lury’s (2004) *Brands: The Logos of the Global Economy* promises to balance the account (see also du Gay et al., 1996). Yet, rooted in cultural studies (see Crane and Bovone, 2006 for an overview of culturalist approaches), Lury’s study does little to remedy the neglect of branding as an integral element of contemporary political economy. That *No Logo*, a book authored by a journalist-activist, has had such an impact by bringing the ‘new branded world’ (Klein, 2000: Ch 1) into some focus is symptomatic of a popular recognition of branding’s contemporary significance and indicative of a scholarly vacuum.

Whatever the source of the antipathy or blindness to the contemporary significance of branding for capitalist expansion (see Marazzi, 2010) and, more recently, for market capitalization (see Frieder and Subrahmanyam, 2004), its comparative neglect is remarkable. Branding is increasingly important in shaping the identity, strategy and structure of organizations (O'Neill, 2001; Schultz et al., 2000)—in the public and not-for-profit as well as the private sectors (see Lury and Moor, 2010). Yet, the role of branding in facilitating the expansion of impersonal, market-mediated economic relations is marginalized in the field of organization studies and in critical (e.g. Marxist) studies of capitalist political economy. In the next section, a schematic history of branding is sketched as a basis for appreciating how, in the present era of financialization, brands are identified as intangible assets with a monetizable value.

The dynamics of branding—a schematic history

Branding was first introduced⁶ to provide assurances to customers that a product or service, such as silvermithing, could be trusted as unadulterated or reliable. In this phase, branding does not differentiate a product or service from reputable substitutes but, instead, provides a *symbolic guarantee of a standardized quality*. In this context, the ethico-political significance of branding resides in its inspiration of confidence which is a critical condition of the expansion of (impersonal, market) exchange. The assurance of a recognizable and trusted brand name, enabled through advertising and promotion, was particularly important for entry into markets where customers had previously relied upon personal knowledge of local producers. Branding facilitates a substitution of branded for unbranded products which is a condition of possibility for enlarging sales, thereby securing an expanding, privately appropriated, surplus from the proceeds.

A second phase or layer of branding places emphasis upon elaborating a *distinctive, symbolic meaning* or 'personality' that differentiates a product or service from rival (branded) competitors. Customers' attention and loyalty is attracted by, for example, associating products with an aspirational life-style. In this phase, fetishising the brand comes to play an increasingly central role in retaining market share and supporting premium pricing. Customer identification and emotional attachment is encouraged, thereby protecting the revenue flows from which a privately appropriated surplus is realized. As Thompson et al. (2007: 634) observe of popular music, 'what is marketed is more than music, it is the "uniqueness" of the act, its look, its "story", as well as its sound'. As they also point out, the development of these qualities—that is, elements of brand equity—'doesn't start after but takes place during the production process' (Thompson et al., 2007: 635). What they omit to appreciate, however, and so represent the prospective consumer of pop music as a passive absorber of the brand 'story', is how consumers are actively involved, as co-creators, in interpreting and assessing this story and are active participants in elaborating and disseminating its narrative—notably, in the contemporary context, through social networking sites.⁷

During the second phase, when the brand is differentiated from other brands, substantial resources are ploughed into styling and mass advertising by employing branding specialists and agencies (see Low and Fullerton, 1994: esp 177 et seq). In this process, the creation of brand equity—in the form of brand awareness and positive associations—is a consequence of successful branding campaigns directed at increasing sales by attracting and retaining customers. The third phase is distinguished by a recognition of how brand equity can, potentially, be *monetized as brand value*—something that becomes very apparent when a company owning a prized brand name is acquired at a price that far exceeds the value ascribed to its physical assets (see Exhibit 2), thereby demonstrating how investment in brand building can produce an intangible asset capable of realizing a dollar value.⁸ Building upon the mass consumption phase of branding, and in particular the

Exhibit 2. The financial importance of brands: Unilever's acquisition of Bestfoods

When Unilever finally succeeded in a US\$8.6 billion takeover of Bestfoods, the primary focus of analysts and fund managers were the leading brands that this would add to the company's financial portfolio. So while institutional investors were pressuring Unilever for more than a decade to reduce its brand portfolio, the financial value attributed to Bestfoods' top brands justified the debt-financed acquisition of this company (IUF, 2006)

institutionalized expansion of consumption through credit, investment in branding, combined with outsourcing of production, becomes a more purposeful, strategic means of increasing the return on capital invested. Feldwick (1996: 85), for example, notes how, in the 1990s,

hardnosed business people began to notice that brands appeared to be changing hands for huge sums of money ... (and) the difference between balance sheet valuations and the prices paid by predators was substantially attributed to the value of brands.

As brand equity becomes a monetized quantity, its dollar value is incorporated into market capitalization (against which cheaper lines of credit and the debt-financing of expansion or acquisition activity can be secured). In an ethico-political complex where financialization becomes the driving source of capital accumulation (see Exhibit 1), the contribution of branding to generating surpluses—for example, through royalties derived from subsidiaries and other companies' use of the brand name—begins to up-stage its (continuing, phase two) role in constructing symbolic value for consumers. A report discussing the emergent strategy of global food companies, such as Nestlé, Kraft and Unilever, published in 1996 was prescient in its observation that

As income from brand royalties contributes a larger proportion of earnings growth there is a stronger motivation to direct investment into raising the value of intangible assets—especially increased expenditure on branding and marketing operations. This means that if the major food transnational corporations (TNCs) exercise control over these brands and focus on branding and marketing, food processing and packaging activities can be outsourced to subcontractors and co-packers ... The fact that the major TNCs can generate a major source of revenue from intangible assets—in this case royalties paid not only by subsidiaries but eventually by co-packers—suggests that this could be the future of the global food industry. (IUF, 2006: 11)

From being an elusive quality that warrants and/or (re)enchants mundane commodities, the intangible qualities of brand equity are translated into a dollar equivalent, in the form of 'brand value'. Exhibit 3 sets out the difference, and relationship, between brand equity and brand value.

From being regarded as a somewhat mysterious way of increasing sales volumes and raising price points, the pay-off of investment in branding becomes articulated more directly as a dollar value that provides an increasingly substantial element of the stock price. Indeed, it has been argued that "'brand managers" primary task is to maximise and leverage brand equity to increase brand value' (Raggio and Leone, 2007: 380; see also Raggio and Leone, 2009). To the extent that financial decision-makers (e.g. stock analysts, fund managers) assess that 'brand owning companies can earn huge returns on their capital and grow faster' (Akasia, 2000: 30), corporate executives, being mindful of the fate of their share price, invest in, and build, brands in a manner that is responsive to such assessments. The suitably inelegant term 'brandization'⁹ is coined here to refer to the leveraging of brand equity to increase the contribution of brand value, as an intangible asset, to market capitalization.

Exhibit 3. Comparing brand equity and brand value

	Brand equity	Brand value
Definition	'The differential effect of brand knowledge on consumer response to the marketing of the brand' (Keller, 1993: 1) (e.g. recognition, image, 'personality', etc.)	The financial valuation given to a branded product, service or company in terms of income, potential income, reputation, prestige, and market value. Brand value is the valorization of brand equity
The Process of translation	'Brand equity'—conceptualized as a distinctive set of assets relating to product awareness, loyalty, quality, etc.—is understood to contribute to shareholder value as it represents 'a reservoir of cash flow that has accumulated from marketing activities but has not yet [been fully] translated into revenue' (Rust et al., 2004: 78, emphasis added; see also Madden et al., 2006)	'From a financial perspective, tangible wealth emanates from the incremental capitalized earnings and cash flows achieved by linking a successful, established brand name to a product or service. These incremental earnings and cash flows came to be labelled <i>brand value</i> ' (Kerin and Sethuraman, 1998: 260, emphasis added)

Brandization

In a 'post-consumer',¹⁰ increasingly financialized, world, the management of brands is increasingly about treating them as 'objects' that can be monetized and leveraged. The monetization of brand equity is significant for at least two reasons. *First*, it underscores how intangible assets, including brands, are increasingly important in the valuation of companies. Simply in order to better understand the distinctive organization and dynamics of contemporary, financialized capitalism, it is relevant to incorporate an examination of how intangible assets are co-created, and how their value is calculated and realized. With specific regard to branding, its study includes the participation of user-consumers in the building of brand equity. The process of co-production in brand-branding occurs in both industrial and consumer markets; and, today, it is most readily evident in internet-based businesses like *Amazon* and *Ebay* where user-consumers willingly provide feedback on goods and sellers that contributes to the appeal, and thus to the brand equity, of those companies.¹¹

Second, the monetization of brand equity invites consideration of whether capital invested in branding can produce a higher rate of return than an equivalent investment in the production of goods and services. This becomes a 'real option' (Baldi and Trigeorgis, 2008) when it is comparatively easy, technically and politically, to outsource manufacturing and/or service delivery (see Alvarez and Stenbacka, 2007). Brandization occurs as the disciplines of finance (including financial accounting) and marketing (including brand management) converge and interact with corporate strategy. In this intersection, intangibles assume increasing significance as a higher proportion of market capitalization is attributed to them. The logic is applied most vigorously by companies such as *Benetton* and especially *Virgin*¹² which leverage the equity in the brand name by applying it to an extended range of products and services;¹³ but, as noted earlier, this logic is also being embraced by longer established companies like *Nestlé* and *Unilever*. In this regard, brandization has significant implications for the (re)structuring of economic organization as companies, pressed

to deliver shareholder value, concentrate upon cultivating and leveraging their intangible assets, including their brands, and outsource other activities (see O'Neil, 2001; Pike and Pollard, 2010). As Davis (2009: 35) comments on Hewlett Packard's decision to outsource much of its manufacturing to a 'board stuffer',

the rationale ultimately turned on the idea that the stock market values intellectual property over tangible assets ... [that is why] cell phones, hot dogs, PCs, pet food and pharmaceuticals are routinely produced by contractors, leaving OEM (Original Equipment Manufacturers) to manage the intellectual property behind these products—patents, brand names, trademarks and research capabilities. (see also Klein, 2000, esp. Ch 8)

Why are these intangibles ascribed greater value? It is because the scope for in-house, post-Fordist squeezing of value from the point of production has diminished relative to what can be achieved by contracting it out, often to offshore manufacturers or service providers operating flexible facilities with lower wage costs and/or regulatory demands. There is often greater potential for generating surplus from intangibles like branding—even allowing for the vulnerability of brand equity to displacement by innovation, shifts in fashion or the risk of its destruction by consumer activists. That said, it should also be born in mind that the contribution of brandization to capital asset growth pales into comparative insignificance when compared to the asset price bubble produced by securitization (Klimecki and Willmott, 2009).¹⁴ Nonetheless, where financial gains are privileged, branding is increasingly identified as a cost-effective means of leveraging capital invested, as will be briefly illustrated later through the example of *Samsung*.

Building brand equity: consumers as co-producers

The business of branding involves a labour process of sign production and dissemination by stylists, packaging specialists, copy writers, media producers, etc., as well as brand managers (Wernick, 1991). In this respect, a focus upon how the contracted labour of brand specialists is harnessed within workplaces remains fully relevant. However, their labour comprises only one side of a co-creation process. When analysis is fixated upon the sphere of production, consumers are (dis)regarded as as their involvement in the production of symbolic values is ignored or trivialized (see Salzer-Mörling and Strannegård, 2004). On the 'unseen' side of the production process is the labour of user-consumers who, at the very least, make assessments of the product or service and thereby actively participate in building (or destroying)¹⁵ brand equity. This point is now developed and illustrated by considering the political economy of brand building in the most contemporary of economies—the Internet—and, more specifically, the contribution of consumers, as co-producers, to the construction of social networking sites.

Co-producing brand equity

With the advent of ICTs, and especially Web 2.0, the co-productive role of user-consumers—which can be subversive¹⁶, as well as constructive—becomes increasingly apparent. Consider ventures such as *Facebook*, *Linkedin* and *YouTube*¹⁷ but also *Google*, *Ebay*, *Tripadvisor* and *Amazon*. The labour of user-consumers directly builds brand equity that, when monetized as brand value, is appropriated by site owners, and not distributed to its content providers. Sites like *YouTube* and *Tripadvisor* are well known and used not because they are heavily advertised or because they employ teams of people producing videos and inspecting hotels. Rather, it is because of the uploading activity and

social networking of user-consumers that such sites enjoy a degree of recognition approaches that of long-established brands like *Coca-Cola* or *Disney*.

There is, of course, no obligation to expend time and effort in up-loading material or making user reviews available; and there is no monetary incentive, such as a wage or piece-work payment, for participating. What, then, is to be made of this 'gift'? Arvidsson (2006, 2008, 2009) contends that it forms part of an 'ethical economy',¹⁸ which generates an 'ethical surplus' (Lazzarato, 1997) in the form of new relationships, meanings and a sense of belonging. This interpretation is persuasive insofar as it draws out the motivation and pleasures associated with such activity. However, in giving it this emphasis, Arvidsson's analysis follows other studies of branding in its 'uneconomised' focus upon 'the individual and social rewards' (Cova and Dalli, 2009: 326). From a *political* cultural *economy* perspective, Arvidsson's otherwise instructive analysis displaces or marginalizes consideration of how the production of such 'ethical surplus' is embedded in capitalist economies (see Bauwens, nd; 2009).

By taking time to leave feedback (e.g. *Amazon*, *Tripadvisor*) as well as by co-designing products and services (e.g. *Nokia Concept Lounge*, *Lego's DesignbyMe*; see also Stalk and Lachenauer, 2004: 119–120), the labour of consumer-users builds brand equity that becomes convertible into brand value—although this value creation may be unapparent and/or of no interest to, co-producers even when the equity produced by their labour in the form of site content or even product development—is sold for very substantial sums.¹⁹

Consider *YouTube*. Founded in February 2005, *YouTube* is where user-consumers upload and share their videos and music clips. *YouTube* was acquired by *Google* for \$1.65bn in 2006 when it had just 65 employees (Arrington, 2006; Helft, 2007). That is a potent illustration of how the labour of user-consumers built the brand equity of *YouTube* that was turned into brand value.²⁰ The proceeds of the sale of *YouTube* were shared amongst those legally credited with owning the site, including share-owning employees, to the exclusion of those who provided its content and built its reputation (see Coombe, 1998). The capitalist state ensured that, legally, the co-producers of *YouTube*'s brand equity had no entitlement to the dollar value generated by their labour.

Needless to say, the appeal of *YouTube* to the owners of *Google* was not the site's design. *Google* staff could readily emulate what had been created by the three ex-*PayPal* employees who established *YouTube*. What *Google* purchased was a brand—*YouTube*—that had become synonymous with videos-on-the-web, and to which a large and growing population of internet users participate as content providers as well as revenue-generating consumers of the advertising placed on *YouTube* the site. The labour expended by user-consumers does not simply create 'ethical value' for site visitors, in the form of clips relevant for identity work and networking. In addition, the uploading of content delivers exchange values which take the form of advertising revenues; and it is the labour of user-consumers that (unintentionally) generates the financial value realized in the sale of *YouTube* to *Google*.

Financialization and branding

The context for understanding how brands have become monetized commodities is the neo-liberal era of the post-1980s in which a liberalization of all markets restored a rate of profit that had been in decline during the 1970s. Reinvigorated by opportunities to trade in a variety of products and coupons (Froud et al., 2002), forms of financial liberalization—collectively conceived as financialization—became a salvationary, bust-beating driver of growth and stability (see Orhangazi, 2008: 49 et seq.). In the UK, this was signalled loudly and triumphantly in 1986 by (the) Big Bang of City deregulation. Amongst many others, Harvey (2005) and Dore (2008)

note how, in the post-1970s era, profit-making shifted from trade and commodity production to the development and use of financial channels (see Krippner, 2005). During these decades, corporate behaviour

became more and more financial in orientation ... it has not been uncommon for corporations to report losses in production offset by gains from financial operations (everything from credit and insurance operations to speculating in volatile currency and futures markets. (Harvey, 2005: 32)

A similar but distinctive angle on financialization is taken here where it is conceived in relation to investment decision-making within corporations and its connectedness to market capitalization. In this context, financialization includes the subjection of investment decision-making to one pre-eminent criterion: what will be added to market capitalization and thereby to shareholder value? For example, if \$1 invested in building brand equity or speculating on currency and/or futures markets is anticipated to produce a higher (short-to-medium term) yield than \$1 invested in new plant, then the financially defensible answer is to offshore or outsource production, and to direct the resources into coupon trading or branding. Processes of financialization unfold as corporate strategies are shaped and assessed in relation to their anticipated effectiveness in defending or raising stock prices (see Dore, 2000; Ezzamel et al., 2009).

Such financialization is, of course, nothing inherently new (Kindleberger and Aliber, 2005). It is perhaps best understood as a potential endemic to capitalism that is released when normative inhibitions (e.g. limits on share-options and bonuses) and regulatory restraints (e.g. the separation of retail and investment banking) are weakened. That said, since the 'Roaring 20s', the boldest experiment with (globalized) financialization, turbo-charged by the use of information and communication technologies for trading and marketing, has occurred during the past two decades. Following the financial meltdown of 2008, the rate of expansion of financialization has been checked but, to date (mid-2010), it has not been halted, let alone reversed. Indeed, the socialization of losses arising from the reckless leveraging of paper assets and trading in exotic financial products (e.g. collateralized debt obligations and credit default swaps; see Klimecki and Willmott, 2009) has served to sustain, not to reform, an economic system that, in the absence of the political will to introduce radical reform, remains structurally geared to financialization.

From building brand equity to calculating brand value

What, then, of marketing activity? How is this redefined and restructured in an era of financialization? From a financialization perspective, its value does not reside primarily in developing or managing an appealing message about a product or service, or even in enabling consumers to interpret this message positively, thereby increasing brand equity and boosting market share. Such outcomes may be satisfying for marketers; and they may be appreciated by consumers. But when applying the discipline of financialization, *simply* increasing the 'brand equity' of products or services—that is, enhancing the positive symbolic meaning—provides a necessary but insufficient justification for continuing investment in marketing. This presents something of a challenge to marketers whose functional role was formed prior to the neo-liberal era of financialization. Marketers have found themselves ill-prepared for a shift in value-orientation in which brand equity has become identified as a significant source of shareholder value. As Lukas et al. (2005) note:

Where in the past, marketing managers were seen as experts on customers, channels, and competitors, they should be seen in the future as experts on how marketing can increase shareholder value. To do this,

marketers need to extend their skill base to add expertise in modern financial planning techniques. (Lukas et al., 2005: 421)

In an era of financialization, marketers are increasingly required to demonstrate how they (and their advertising agencies, see following quote) can reshape and justify their role in terms of its contribution to developing intangible assets that ‘deliver to the bottom line’:

Advertising can frequently be the difference between two products ... We think of ourselves as part of the manufacturing process, building advertising properties that fortify brands that *in themselves become company assets and deliver to the bottom line*. (Bartle et al., 1996: 9, cited in Nixon, 2002: 144, emphasis added)

Where financialization takes hold, shareholder value creation becomes a more explicit and exclusive objective of strategic decision-making, including investment in branding. Marketing and, more specifically, the value attributed to a company’s brands, is then appraised according to its contribution to market capitalization. As Lindemann (2004: 37) summarizes this development:

in the pursuit of increasing shareholder value, companies are keen to establish procedures for the management of brands that are aligned with those for other business assets, as well as for the company as a whole ... Economic value creation becomes the focus of brand management and all brand-related investment decisions. Companies as diverse as American Express, IBM, Samsung Electronics, Accenture, United Way of America, BP, Fujitsu and Duke Energy have used brand valuation to help them refocus their businesses on their brands and to create an economic rationale for branding decisions and investments. Many companies have made brand value creation part of the remuneration criteria for senior marketing executives. (Lindemann, 2004)

The body of literature connecting brand value to market capitalization is slender but developing.²¹ Studies addressing the relationship between the positive valuation of brands and stock price performance point to a strongly positive relationship (for a review of the emergent literature, see Srinivasan and Hanssens, 2008 and commentary by Kimbrough and McAlister, 2008); and studies in behavioral finance indicate that brand visibility directly influences the chances of a stock being bought and held. Frieder (2004: 33, 35), for example, reports that ‘a preference for visible, brand-name stocks in individuals’ decisions to hold stocks supports the hypothesis that individual investors exhibit a propensity towards companies with easily recognisable products’. Investment in branding to create ‘brand-name stocks’ can be a cost-effective means of increasing market capitalization. It is notable that intangibles, of which ‘brands’ form a substantial part, now far outstrip traditional accounting assets as a percentage of market value. As Ballou et al. (2004) comment:

About 20 years ago traditional accounting assets composed about 80% of market value. By March 2000, this ratio had flipped to a peak point where the traditional accounting assets only composed about 15 percent of market value. Despite the subsequent market crash, *traditional accounting assets still explain only about 25% of market value...Some academics and thought leaders make the case that intangible assets such as powerful brands, are the difference*. Whether they make up the entire difference or not, that they play a large role fits well with the evidence that businesses are becoming less dependent on physical assets for value creation (Ballou et al., 2004: 29, emphasis added; see also Lev, 2001)

The position is indeed curious. The value attributed to brands can, and from 2005 must, be included in the balance sheet *only* when there has been an active market in this asset—for example, in the

process of its acquisition (Whitwell, 2005). The balance sheets of companies like *Nike*, *Microsoft* and *Coca-Cola* present information on working capital, net fixed assets and financial investments but are silent on what is arguably their most significant asset, their brand name. As a consequence, there are huge differences between the book value of such companies, as calculated by accountants, and their market value as determined by financial analysts and the decisions of investors (see Tollington, 2001).²² That is because the decision-making of analysts and investors is influenced by non-accounting information which includes assessments of the increasing (or diminishing) value of a company's brand(s).

Struggles over brand valuation

In order to make decisions, analysts and investors want information about intangibles, and not least when these assets are assessed to comprise a significant proportion of market value, even if information on these assets is deemed insufficiently reliable to be included by the preparers and auditors of financial statements (see Barth et al., 1998: 63).²³

As financial statements prepared and audited by accountants do not provide this information, other players, notably branding consultancies, have filled the information vacuum. Each method of evaluating brands claims to place brand valuation, and its contribution to the value of capital assets, upon a more rational or 'scientific' basis (see Valuation Methods and Shareholder Value Fernández, 2001; Fernández, 2002: chapter 13 for a discussion of methods developed by different consultancies). The most prominent of the brand valuation consultancies is *Interbrand* which, in association with *Business Week*, calculates and publishes an annual league table listing the changing contribution of brands to market capitalization (see Exhibit 4).²⁴

Brand valuation methods are based upon some combination of price premium, earnings valuation, royalty payments, market value or historic cost (see Kerin and Sethuraman, 1998; Tollington, 2001), and these are highly contested.²⁵ For marketers, methods based upon accounting-relevant measures are unacceptable or suspect as they are assessed to draw insufficiently upon, and therefore fail to reflect the value of, a marketing perspective and associated expertise (see Roslender and Hart, 2006). A flavour of the antagonism towards accounting-based metrics can be gained from the following comment:

Although there is a danger the figure will be hopelessly inaccurate, the accountants are keen to gain control of brands by valuing them without a marketing contribution. If marketers are to control the brands they

Exhibit 4. The contribution of brands to market capitalization (source: Business Week 2007, Interbrand/JP Morgan)

Company	2002 brand value (\$bn)	Brand contribution to market capitalization of parent company (%)	2001 brand value (\$bn)
Coca-Cola	69.6	51	69.0
Microsoft	64.1	21	65.1
IBM	51.2	39	52.8
GE	41.3	14	42.4
Intel	30.9	22	34.7
Nokia	30.0	51	35.0
Disney	29.3	68	32.6
McDonalds	26.4	71	25.3

consider themselves responsible for, it is imperative that they get and stay involved in the brand valuation process. Greater financial visibility will increase corporate understanding of the value that brands and those responsible for them contribute to the enterprise. (Whitwell, 2005: 3).

The contest is over how to quantify brand equity, and which management specialism should control this process. On the one side, accountants favour excluding the value of intangibles from the balance sheet unless they are newly acquired, in which case they have a recently demonstrated monetary value. To marketers, on the other side, reliance upon accounting metrics produces values that are ‘hopelessly inaccurate’, not least because the balance sheet fails to do justice to marketers’ brand-building contribution to the company’s market valuation. There is a parallel here with securitization. The conservative position is that the value of securities must always be directly supported by the so-called ‘fundamentals’²⁶ of the tangible assets held on the balance sheet. That view gives only limited encouragement to the process of brandization, including the securitization of brands (Taylor et al., 2009). The conservative position unravels when financial analysts and investors are persuaded, or convince themselves, that hitherto unregistered value resides in an intangible, such as a brand; and they rely upon the providers of non-accounting valuations in a way that parallels how fund managers rely upon securities’ ratings agencies to inform and warrant their buy/ hold/ sell decisions (see Nicholai et al., 2009).

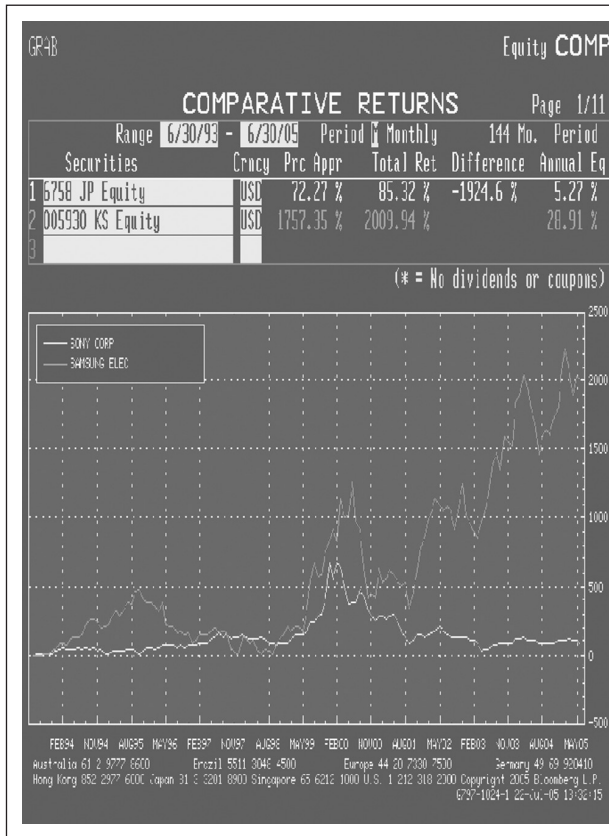
That said, precisely how assessments of brand-name stocks influence the decision-making of investors and executives remains opaque. Gaining permission to conduct observational research in financial markets is notoriously difficult (see MacKenzie, 2009: 179). As a consequence, little research has been undertaken on how analysts, rating agencies and investors use information, including the information provided by consultancies like *Interbrand* or *FinanceWorld*. Their illumination would require access to ‘company insiders who are privy to more of the circumstances that affect brand equity’ (Simon and Sullivan, 1993: 49). In the absence of such research, one publicly available source of information is company annual reports where major investments—in acquisitions, for example, but also in branding—are justified to shareholders. The significance of investment in branding is now illustrated with the example of *Samsung*.

Samsung: conjuring value from branding

In his 2007 message to shareholders, the CEO of *Samsung* states:

We have focused on various marketing activities for our premium products to enhance our brand value. Consequently, we took 10th place in the world and 7th place among global IT companies in a survey co-conducted by Interbrand and Business Week, with an estimated brand value of \$16.1 billion in 2006, up from \$15 billion of 2005. (Lee, 2007)

This statement is suggestive of how seriously brand valuation may be taken as a key indicator of corporate performance. Little more than a decade earlier, *Samsung* was a supplier to OEMs and a manufacturer of ‘cheap knockoffs’. As a company, it lacked any common brand identity; it was a ‘house of brands’ which enjoyed minimal recognition and positive evaluation by consumers, and so lacked brand equity (See Exhibit 5). In the mid-1990s, a decision was taken to abandon the numerous brands and to market *Samsung* as a corporate brand—a strategy commended by contemporary pundits (e.g. Rao et al., 2004) as particularly cost-effective and value-enhancing. Accompanying this change was a decision to concentrate upon the development flagship products that consumers use on a daily basis—the mobile phone, the flat screen television, the



Possibly, no brand has done a better job of mining the potential of new brand building principles than *Samsung*. Less than a decade ago it was the maker of lower-end consumer electronics under a handful of brand names including *Wisewiew*, *Tantus*, and *Yepp*, none of which meant much to consumers. Figuring that its only shot at moving up the value chain was to build a stronger identity, the company ditched all its other brands to put all its resources behind the *Samsung* name. Then it focused on building a more upscale image through better quality, design and innovations ... Most people carry their mobile phones with them everywhere, while TV is the center of the family room. 'We wanted the brand in users' presence 24/7', says Peter Weedfald, Head of *Samsung's* North American Marketing and Consumer Electronics Unit. Now that strategy is paying off. Over the past five years, *Samsung* (#20) has posted the biggest gain in value of any Global 100 brand, with a 186% surge. (Business Week, 2005)

Exhibit 5. The market performance of Samsung and Sony, February 2004 to May 2005

netbook, etc. Today, *Samsung* occupies a market position where it competes head-to-head with established global brands such as *Sony* and *Phillips*. Exhibit 5 compares the share price movement of *Sony* and *Samsung* from February 2004 to May 2005 and is accompanied by a *Business Week* commentary on the success of *Samsung's* conversion, or leverage, of increased brand equity into enlarged brand value.

As an integral part of its strategy to penetrate and dominate established markets, *Samsung* reportedly 'used extensive data on market variables, brand share, marketing expenses and other variables, and ran simulations to understand how and where marketing investments yielded the highest returns' (Chu and Keh, 2006: 329 citing Corstjens and Merrihue, 2003). In this respect, there is a parallel between models developed to calculate return on investment from in-house versus outsourced production with calculations about the contribution to market capitalization from investment in the co-production of symbolic values that build brand equity. Outsourcing of production is comparatively easy to establish but also easy to copy. From its years supplying OEMs, *Samsung* had cost-effective manufacturing facilities, so outsourcing was not an appealing strategic option. The decision to reinvent the company as a prized global brand has, of course, required huge investment in product development and state-of-the-art production plants in addition to massive marketing investment. The strategy is also vulnerable

to user-consumers' fickle involvement in the co-production of symbolic value that can extend to its subversion.²⁷ Yet, as the remarks of the CEO indicate, when investment in brand building is effectively harnessed to product development and competitive pricing, it can make a very substantial contribution to shareholder value.

A cautionary note must be sounded, nonetheless. The link between investment in activities intended to increase brand equity and the emphasis upon supporting the stock price is difficult to demonstrate as little research has been undertaken on how calculations about the contribution of branding to market capitalization inform executives' investment decision-making. In the case of *Samsung*, some indication of how the strategy was forged, and is being maintained, can be gleaned from examining the formation and activities of the Global Strategy Group²⁸ and also in the 2003 message from the Chairman of *Samsung* in which he announces 'The Next Phase' in the company's development:

As a company, we are learning that we can remain vital only as long as we pursue *our goal of becoming one of the world's most admired brands*. The forces driving Samsung to become a top global brand are already in place: the people, processes, partners and products. (emphasis added)²⁹

In its quest to establish *Samsung* as a 'top global brand', the three phases, or layers, of branding which were sketched earlier have been strategically combined and compressed. Samsung has concentrated primarily upon increasing brand recognition and esteem, using billboards to plaster its logo and products across the planet and associating these with prestigious events and associated life-styles. First, and foremost, however, and as the CEO's 2007 message to the company's shareholders suggests, investing in branding is justified as a strategic means of increasing 'brand value' and thereby increasing market capitalization.

Summary and conclusion

The article has offered a political cultural economy analysis of branding and its valorization. The insertion of 'cultural' between 'political' and 'economy' recalls that social practices, including their analysis, are ethico-political in formulation: the (re)construction of reality involves a particular, culturally meaningful engagement with a meaningless and 'ethically irrational' world. There is no pretence that analysis of social phenomena (e.g. of branding) can objectively or 'scientifically' disclose their essential features or 'value'. What counts as 'value' is conceived here as an outcome of struggles through which some meanings are privileged and particular ethico-political complexes become institutionalized and naturalized. It is through these struggles that specific notions of 'value'—whether neo-classical, Marxian or post-Marxian—become established and exert their effects.

Diverse literatures—marketing, accounting and finance as well as organization studies and the sociologies of work and consumption—have been drawn together to illuminate how the creation and realization of value through branding forms an increasingly significant part of a 'big picture'³⁰ of contemporary capitalism. Specifically, the focus has been upon how brand equity is co-produced by user-consumers and translated into monetized value that makes an increasingly substantial contribution to the dividends and capital gains enjoyed by investors. In this respect, the analysis shares Marxian concerns about the conditions of wealth production and the justice of its distribution. But the basis of this concern is ethico-political; there is no presumption that, for example, the oppressive and exploitative nature of capitalist political economy and/or work organization can be scientifically demonstrated, or that the course of its demise can be predicted.

In order to show the ‘bigger picture’, three elements within the ‘full circuit’ of capitalist reproduction have been connected: control over the surpluses generated by *labour* (e.g. user-consumers of branded products) that command a price premium; the realization of surplus through control of revenues derived from sales of *products*; and the appropriation of surplus in the form of *capital* accumulation, after deduction of costs. The growing importance of the production of intangible assets (e.g. brands) has been linked to processes of financialization; and ‘brandization’ has been situated with the dynamics of neo-liberal capitalist expansion. The analysis has illuminated how the labour of user-consumers is mobilized to build brand equity which, through a process of ‘brandization’, is converted into privately appropriated wealth.

In an era of financialization, brand equity is being targeted and leveraged as an hitherto neglected source of market capitalization and shareholder value. When disciplined by financialization, investment in branding is not primarily or ultimately justified in relation to the benefits ascribed to consumers, to penetrating new markets, or to growing market share. Rather, investment is warranted by its anticipated contribution to shareholder value as illustrated by the example of *Samsung*. As branding becomes financialized, attention shifts from brand building *per se* to how this activity can be monetized and leveraged for valorisation. With the advent of ‘brandization’, branding becomes ‘a distinctive mode of capital accumulation’ (Holt, 2006: 300). Whereas *branding* can re-enchant mundane, tired or unloved products and services, *brandization* leverages their value for investors, and thereby recuperates capitalism as an ethico-political complex.

Notes

Earlier versions of the article were presented at the ‘Re-thinking Cultural Economy Conference’, Centre for Research on Socio-Cultural Change, University of Manchester, September 2007 and at seminar presentations at Cardiff, Cambridge, Lund and Nottingham Trent Universities. I am grateful for comments and conversations arising from these presentations that have enabled me to develop the article. The article has also greatly benefitted from comments provided by referees and the editors of this special issue.

- 1 For example, contemporary commentaries on differences in propositions about ‘value creation’ are inclined to suggest that these speak to its ‘different dimensions’ (Lepak et al., 2007: 181).
- 2 See also note 30.
- 3 For reasons of space, discussion of the critical tradition is confined to Marxian analysis which, arguably, has been particularly influential in studies of economic organization including labour process studies.
- 4 This is not to suggest that the ‘object’, such as ‘brand value’, is reducible to the framework. On the contrary, objects always escape efforts of theory to disclose their features (see Glynos and Haworth, 2007). What we know about ‘objects’ is incorrigibly limited by the interpretive frameworks deployed to characterize and examine them. From this standpoint, objects of analysis are elusive as they cannot be disentangled from what gives the ‘object’ visibility and significance (see Barud, 2007, especially chapter 8) within particular ethico-political complexes.
- 5 See, for example, the Research Priorities (2006–8) of the Marketing Science Institute at http://www.msi.org/pdf/MSI_RP06-08.pdf accessed 29 December 2007.
- 6 For a fuller history of branding, see Moor (2007).
- 7 The example is given by Thompson et al. (2007). They describe a branding agency specializing in ‘truly holistic identities’ that was used to create an image for Keane, a British popular music band—something that is alleged to have been kept secret because it contravened conventional ideas of rock authenticity. This view assumes a touching degree of naivety and/or concern amongst Keane fans but it also projects upon them a set of values (e.g. about the inappropriateness of involving professional image generators)

with which they may not identify. As it happens, Keane themselves clearly did take exception to the allegation and issued a spirited and stinging rebuttal of any suggestion that Moving Brands, the branding agency, had manufactured their image. See <http://www.keaneshaped.co.uk/faq/#stylist>. The existence of this public domain rebuttal, which would seem to cast further doubt upon the band's desire to hush it up, seems to have escaped the attention of Thompson et al. (2007) who make no reference to it.

- 8 The purchase of Kraft by Philip Morris in 1988 is widely regarded as a pivotal moment when most of the purchase price of \$12.6m was attributed to 'the cost of the word "Kraft"'. Instead of being regarded as an 'add-on' to the core business of production and sales, 'a huge dollar value had been assigned to something that had previously been abstract and unquantifiable—a brand name' (Klein, 2000: 7–8).
- 9 The neologism is intended to resonate with 'securitization', the latter being the key driver of contemporary financialized capital asset growth characterized by some as 'fictitious capital'.
- 10 The term 'post-consumer' does not imply that consumption stops or even declines but, rather, that it is sustained and driven on by processes of financialization, most notably by developing ingenious ways of expanding credit for purposes of consumption.
- 11 As a thought experiment, imagine how the brand equity, and ultimately the market capitalization, of *Ebay* would be damaged if all information provided by sellers and buyers was erased or if the company was obliged to compensate those providing feedback.
- 12 *Virgin's* brand-centric stratagem is particularly 'clever' as so much of the brand equity is acquired cheaply by engaging in media stunts, often ending in heroic failure, that attract global publicity.
- 13 Branson, the CEO of *Virgin*, has defined his empire as 'a leading branded venture capital organization', seeking 30 per cent internal rates of return on investments. 'The Value of Virgin', *Daily Telegraph* 3 December 2007. Available at <http://www.telegraph.co.uk/money/main.jhtml?xml=/money/2007/12/02/ccrock102.xml>. See also Osborne (2007).
- 14 To which the growth of speculative corporate treasury activity *within* companies has significantly contributed.
- 15 The contingency of brand-building means that consumers may drain brands of value as well as infuse them with worth—as is evident in the (temporary?) loss of 'coolness' of brands such as Gap as well as McDonalds and Starbucks (see Thompson et al., 2006) and also in the subversive, culture-jamming activities pursued by campaigning groups like 'Adbusters' (see Holt, 2002).
- 16 An illustrative example is the extensive but divided involvement of a *Lego* 'brand community' in the development of its product *Mindstorm*. Its user-consumers were key initiators and facilitators of product development but they were also resistant to aspects of it (see www.fbtb.com) The interested reader is encouraged to turn to Kornberger (in press) and Antorini (2007). Recognition of such resistance points to the emergence of other, potentially more subversive, forms of co-produced value creation (see Bauwens, 2009)—in the form of peer-to-peer production that escapes private appropriation as it is protected by a general public license that, our course, also makes it available to commercial users.
- 17 *Linux* is a prominent example.
- 18 As participants in the 'ethical economy', user-consumers, such as 'the programmer who decides to spend his evening hours coding away at the Linux kernel' (Arvidsson, 2009: 22), are seen to engage in co-production to create and elaborate their identities, life-styles and friendship networks. Attentiveness to how 'self-organized forms of production', mediated by ICTs 'contain(ing) the possibility of a new, rational way of organizing social and economic processes' (Arvidsson, 2009: 14), offers a useful corrective to labour process analysts' myopic focus upon paid labour in workplaces (see O'Doherty and Willmott, 2009). It also suggests how ICT-mediated, commons-oriented, peer production of value unleashes what Marx terms 'General Intellect'—in the form of 'networks, tacit knowledge and social organization' on 'a societal scale, which is difficult to control and measure' (Arvidsson, nd). In the field of organization studies, Land and Böhm (2009) offer the most developed discussion of Arvidsson's

'ethical economy' thesis. They follow Arvidsson's (2006) debt to Lazzarato's (1997, 2007) notion of the 'political entrepreneur' who, in contrast to the economic entrepreneur, is conceived to mobilize 'community, affect and communicative flows' (Arvidsson, 2006: 89). Of most direct relevance for the present focus upon branding, the idea of 'political entrepreneurship' is assessed by Land and Böhm (2009) to be useful in appreciating how marketing has been extended from a 'technique for selling' into a 'mechanism', notably in the form of brand management, 'that is constitutive of social relations, information and values for the market' (Lazzarato, 2007: 92 cited in Land and Böhm, 2009: 10). Such entrepreneurship is characterized as 'political' because it is not directly economic in any established sense: it involves the production of meaning and subjectivity rather than the manufacture of goods. Land and Böhm (2009) largely overlook post-Bravermanian labour process analysis, especially that influenced by Foucault, which addresses the production of meaning and subjectivity in the manufacture of goods and services (see O'Doherty and Willmott, 2009). Also conspicuously absent from their discussion is any reference to the formation of capital and, more specifically, consideration of how capital is accumulated through the translation of brand equity into brand value. The closest they come is when, in passing, they note that 'brand management continuously seeks to govern the production of immaterial value so as to realize it as economic value' (Land and Böhm: 14). There is no direct recognition of how the co-produced brand equity contributes to market capitalization—something that, as noted earlier, becomes most apparent when companies (e.g. *Kraft*, *YouTube*) are acquired.

- 19 As noted earlier, the chief exception to this private appropriation of the brand value generated by unpaid labour is where production is governed by a general public license. This licence ensures that brand equity cannot be directly monetized, although, as Bauwens (2009: 125) observes, companies 'can do many things to indirectly capture the value created by peer-producing communities'.
- 20 It seems doubtful that the architects of *YouTube* ever conceived of themselves as engaging in a community service, or a charitable venture, devised to facilitate the donation of 'ethical labour' for socially beneficial purposes. If they did, then their venture did not remain charitable for long (see <http://www.nytimes.com/2007/02/07/technology/07cnd-google.html?ex=1328504400&en=96fcc0326d0a7ef6&ei=5088&partner=rssnyt&emc=rss>).
- 21 In a recent review of these studies, de Beijer (2008) notes that: 'Barth et al. (1998) estimate the association between *FinancialWorld* brand value estimates and share prices over the period 1991 to 1996. They find a significant positive association. Kerin and Sethuraman (1998) study US consumer goods companies on the 1995 and 1996 *FinancialWorld's* Most-Valued Brands list and report a positive relation between brand value estimates and firm value. They also find some indications that increases in brand values are more likely to be reflected in firm value than are decreases in brand values. Custodio and Rosario (2007) and Delcours (2008) also find a positive association between brand value estimates and firm value for US companies. Pahud de Mortanges and van Riel (2003) measure brand equity for Dutch corporate brands using Young and Rubicam's Brand Asset Valuator. They find a significant association between this brand value indicator and various shareholder value measures'.
- 22 Accounting specialists are reluctant to include intangibles on the balance sheet even though their absence places in question the claimed 'representational faithfulness' of financial statements. The exclusion of intangibles is defended on the grounds that measures of intangible value lack the reliability attributed to those used to value tangible assets. This justification is contested by others who suggest that the valuation of tangible assets presents comparable difficulties: 'it is well known that allocations, such as depreciation, are often arbitrary [and] the allocation of value between land and buildings is well accepted despite its indeterminate nature' (Power, 1992: 49). From this perspective, the 'unreliability of measures' argument is viewed as something of a smokescreen for a failure of collective will to agree a conception of reliability that will support a common measure of a brand's value: 'If what "accountants are currently prepared to recognise" is a contingent matter, then any attempt to shift the consensus of accepted practice

is “political” in the sense that the widespread credibility of a new body of “expert” recognition knowledge must be established’ (Power, 1992: 51). The problem is that, politically, a substantial measure of agreement on the measurement of tangibles has been brokered but has not (yet) been extended to the valuation of intangibles.

- 23 As indicated in the previous note, accountants are strongly inclined to use and defend a method of valuation, underpinned by a particular conception of reliability, that predates the era of the intangible asset.
- 24 The methodology for calculating the contribution of brand value to market capitalization is contested. A number of consultancies offer rival methodologies although *Interbrand* is by far the most influential. In essence, the *Interbrand* methodology strips out operating costs, taxes, and charges for the capital employed to arrive at the earnings attributable to intangible assets. The contribution of the brand is estimated within those earnings in relation to other intangible assets (e.g. patents and management strength). Future earnings are discounted to arrive at a net present value. *Interbrand* discounts against current interest rates and also against the brand’s overall risk profile so as to factor-in brand strength. See http://www.businessweek.com/pdfs/2007/0732_globalbrands.pdf. See also Kerin and Suthuraman (1998: 271–2)
- 25 See Lury and Moor (2010) for a sociologically informed discussion.
- 26 ‘So-called’ because their apparent bedrock solidity is precarious. In common with all measures of value, tangible assets rely upon the buoyancy of confidence to sustain their worth.
- 27 This is evident, for example, in a frequently downloaded home video that criticizes one of Samsung’s viral marketing campaigns. See <http://gizmodo.com/gadgets/gadgets/us-to-samsung-viral-marketing-doesnt-work-please-stop-168495.php> (accessed 4 November 2009).
- 28 See http://www.molinu.org/samsung_global_strategy_group (accessed 4 November 2009).
- 29 See http://www.samsung.com/co/aboutsamsung/samsunggroup/annualreport/downloads/2003/SAMAR04_01_10p.pdf (accessed 4 November 2009).
- 30 Other attempts to do something similar include Thompson (2003) and Littler (2009).

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Biography

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